

Gospel of Thomas Saying 1: The Interpretation of the Sayings and the Mystery of Death

A Textual, Linguistic, Comparative, and Theological Study

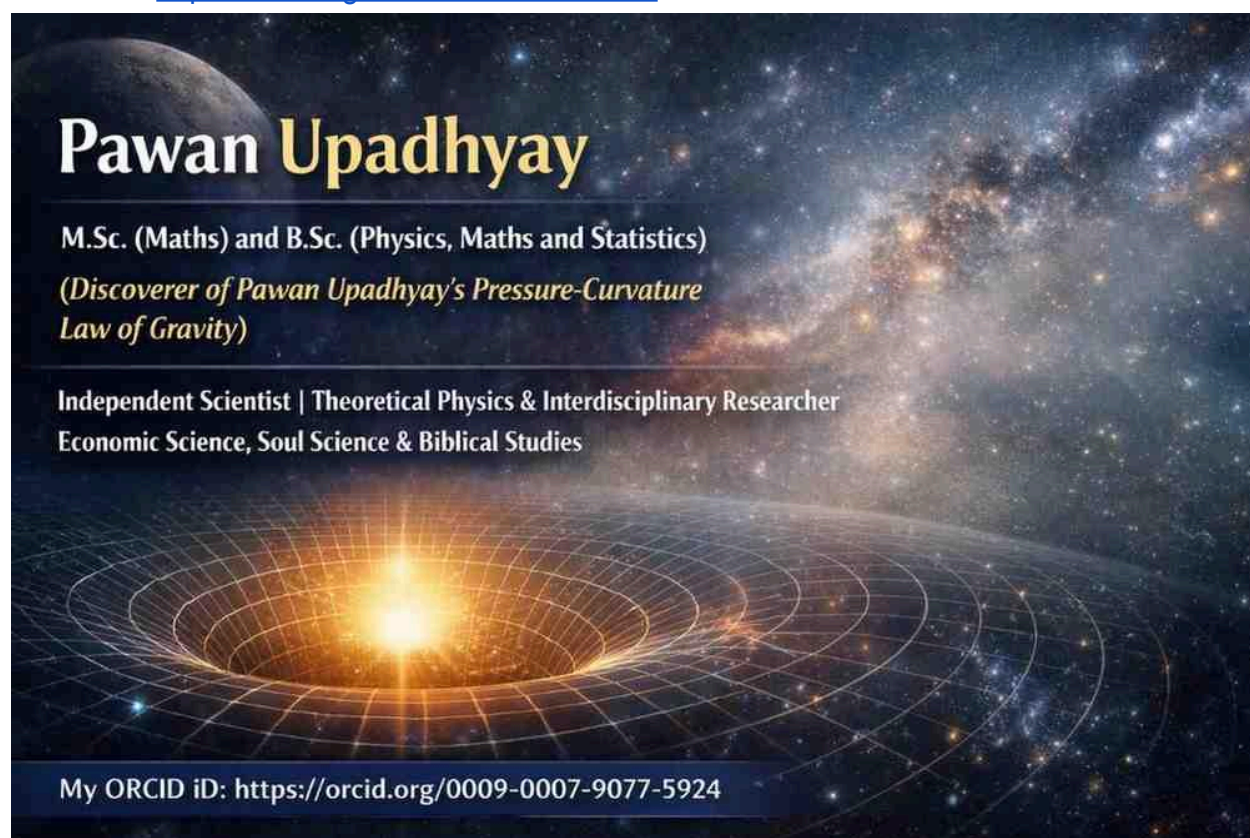
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Abstract

The first saying of the *Gospel of Thomas* presents one of the most striking statements in early Christian sayings literature:

“Whoever finds the interpretation of these sayings will not taste death.”

The statement is remarkable because it connects the **interpretation of Jesus' sayings** with the overcoming of **death**. Unlike the canonical Gospels, the *Gospel of Thomas* is primarily a collection of sayings attributed to Jesus rather than a narrative of His ministry, death, and resurrection. Saying 1 therefore functions as an interpretive key for the collection as a whole.

This study examines Saying 1 through its surviving Coptic and Greek witnesses, investigates the principal Greek concepts underlying “finds,” “interpretation,” “sayings,” and “taste death,” and compares the saying with related statements in the canonical Gospels, particularly John 8:51, John 6:63–68, John 11:25–26, and Matthew 13:11. The study argues that Saying 1 should not be treated simply as a promise of esoteric information. Its central theological question is more profound: **what does it mean to discover the meaning of Jesus' sayings, and what relationship does that discovery have to life and death?**

The comparison with the canonical Gospels demonstrates important conceptual parallels while also revealing significant differences. In John, eternal life is inseparable from the person of Jesus Himself: He is the Word, the Life, the Resurrection, and the one whose word gives life. Thus, when Saying 1 is read within the broader early Christian tradition, its mystery may be understood not merely as the acquisition of hidden knowledge but as the discovery of the reality to which the sayings point.

1. Introduction

The *Gospel of Thomas* begins differently from the four canonical Gospels.

Matthew begins with genealogy and the story surrounding Jesus' birth. Mark begins with the proclamation of John the Baptist. Luke begins with a historical prologue. John begins with the eternal **Logos**, declaring:

“In the beginning was the Word.”

The *Gospel of Thomas*, however, begins with sayings.

Its opening identifies the collection as the **hidden or secret sayings** spoken by the “living Jesus.” Saying 1 then immediately gives the reader a warning—or an invitation:

“Whoever finds the interpretation of these sayings will not taste death.”

This statement is extraordinarily important for understanding Thomas.

The reader is not simply being invited to read the sayings.

The reader is being invited to **understand** them.

And the consequence of understanding is presented in terms of **death**.

Thus the first saying establishes a fundamental relationship:

Sayings → interpretation → discovery → life → victory over death.

This raises several questions:

1. What exactly does “interpretation” mean?
2. What are the “sayings” that must be interpreted?
3. What does it mean to “taste death”?
4. Is the promise literal, metaphorical, spiritual, or eschatological?
5. How does Saying 1 relate to Jesus' sayings in the canonical Gospels?
6. Can the saying be connected to the Aramaic-speaking world of Jesus?
7. Does the saying ultimately point beyond Jesus' words to Jesus Himself?

These questions make Saying 1 worthy of careful textual and theological investigation.

2. The Gospel of Thomas and Its Manuscript Tradition

The complete surviving *Gospel of Thomas* is preserved in **Nag Hammadi Codex II**, written in Coptic. The Coptic manuscript contains 114 sayings attributed to Jesus. The manuscript itself belongs to the fourth-century Nag Hammadi codex tradition.

However, the Coptic manuscript is not our only witness.

Greek fragments of Thomas were discovered at Oxyrhynchus in Egypt. One of these, **P.Oxy. 654**, preserves the prologue and sayings 1–7. The Greek fragment is therefore particularly important because it provides an ancient Greek witness to the opening of Thomas.

The relationship between the Greek fragments and the Coptic text is especially valuable for textual study. The Greek witnesses preserve portions of Thomas that correspond substantially with the Coptic Gospel found at Nag Hammadi.

This gives us two important textual stages:

Greek Thomas → Coptic Thomas

The existence of the Greek fragments also means that Saying 1 cannot be studied exclusively through the later Coptic manuscript.

3. The Text of Saying 1

The Coptic tradition is commonly translated:

“Whoever finds the interpretation of these sayings will not experience death.”

Other translations render the final expression:

“Whoever finds the meaning of these sayings will not taste death.”

The Greek Oxyrhynchus witness similarly preserves:

“Whoever finds the interpretation of these sayings will not taste death.”

The differences between “experience death” and “taste death” are primarily translation choices. The underlying imagery of **tasting death** is especially important because it connects the saying with biblical and Jewish idiomatic language concerning experiencing death.

4. “These Sayings”: λόγια and the Nature of Jesus' Words

One of the most important words in the Greek tradition is **λόγια (logia)**, commonly translated “sayings,” “words,” or “oracles.”

The title traditionally given to Thomas itself reflects this sayings-oriented character.

Jesus is introduced as the **living Jesus**, and the text presents His words as a collection requiring interpretation.

This is significant.

Thomas does not begin by explaining Jesus' death and resurrection.

Instead, it begins with:

the living Jesus speaking.

The reader is therefore directed toward the words of the living Christ.

This creates an important theological question:

Why do the sayings possess such significance that discovering their interpretation can be associated with escaping death?

The answer cannot simply be that the sayings contain useful moral advice.

The saying itself gives them a much greater significance.

5. “Finding” the Interpretation

The verb traditionally translated “finds” is associated with the Greek verb εὕρισκω (**heuriskō**)—to find, discover, or come upon.

The wording therefore suggests an active process.

The reader must **seek and find**.

This is immediately reinforced by Saying 2:

“The one who seeks should not cease seeking until he finds.”

This sequence is important.

Saying 1 introduces:

finding the interpretation.

Saying 2 immediately develops:

seeking until finding.

Consequently, the first two sayings appear intentionally connected.

The reader is not expected to passively receive information.

The reader must search.

6. What Does “Interpretation” Mean?

The Greek term commonly reconstructed here is related to ἑρμηνεία (*hermēneia*), meaning interpretation, explanation, or interpretation of meaning.

This is one of the most significant words in Saying 1.

The promise is not simply:

“Whoever hears these sayings will not taste death.”

Nor does it simply say:

“Whoever memorizes these sayings will not taste death.”

It says, in effect:

Whoever discovers their interpretation will not taste death.

This makes **understanding** central.

The mystery is therefore not merely in hearing Jesus' words.

It is in penetrating their meaning.

This distinction is essential.

7. The Mystery of “Taste Death”

The expression “**taste death**” is particularly striking.

To taste something is to experience it.

The phrase therefore conveys more than simply intellectual awareness of death.

It suggests experiencing death personally.

The promise is consequently radical:

The person who discovers the meaning of the sayings will not experience death in the ultimate sense.

This raises a major theological question.

Does Thomas mean that the interpreter will never physically die?

The text itself does not explain the statement.

Therefore several interpretations are possible.

7.1 Physical immortality

One possible interpretation is that the saying promises literal freedom from physical death.

However, such a reading creates difficulties because the statement is not accompanied by an explanation of how physical mortality is overcome.

7.2 Spiritual immortality

The saying may refer to a form of spiritual life in which death no longer possesses ultimate power.

7.3 Eschatological life

The saying may refer to ultimate life beyond death—the kind of life associated elsewhere in early Christianity with resurrection and salvation.

7.4 Transformative knowledge

The statement may also indicate that discovering the true meaning of Jesus' teaching transforms one's understanding of existence so profoundly that death is no longer understood as the ultimate reality.

These possibilities should not automatically be collapsed into one another.

A responsible interpretation must recognize that the text itself is brief and enigmatic.

8. Comparison with John 8:51

One of the most important canonical comparisons is John 8:51:

“If anyone keeps my word, he will never see death.”

The conceptual similarity is remarkable.

Thomas:

Find the interpretation of the sayings → will not taste death.

John:

Keep my word → will never see death.

Both statements connect:

Jesus' word → death → life beyond death.

Yet there is also an important difference.

Thomas emphasizes **finding the interpretation**.

John emphasizes **keeping Jesus' word**.

Thomas therefore stresses understanding.

John stresses obedience and relationship to Jesus' word.

The two should not be declared identical. They belong to different textual contexts and theological frameworks. Nevertheless, their conceptual proximity deserves attention.

9. Comparison with John 6:63–68

John provides another particularly important parallel.

Jesus says:

“The words that I have spoken to you are spirit and are life.”

Peter then responds:

“You have the words of eternal life.”

This is highly relevant to Thomas Saying 1.

Thomas associates understanding Jesus' sayings with escaping death.

John associates Jesus' words with **life** and specifically **eternal life**.

The conceptual structure becomes:

Jesus' words → life → eternal life → victory over death.

The difference is that John goes further by connecting the life-giving words with Jesus' identity.

Jesus does not merely possess words that give life.

He Himself declares:

“I am the life.”

10. Jesus as the Living Word

The theology of the Gospel of John provides a profound framework for understanding the significance of Jesus' sayings.

John begins:

“In the beginning was the Word.”

Then:

“The Word became flesh.”

The eternal Word became human in Jesus Christ.

This creates a distinction that is important for theological interpretation:

Jesus is not merely a teacher who possesses divine information.

In Johannine theology, Jesus is Himself the **Word**.

Therefore His words have significance because of **who He is**.

This leads to a deeper theological interpretation of Thomas Saying 1:

Perhaps the mystery is not merely hidden information contained in the sayings.

Perhaps the sayings ultimately point to **the Living One who speaks them**.

11. The “Living Jesus”

The prologue of Thomas describes the sayings as those spoken by the **living Jesus**.

This phrase is extremely important.

Jesus is not presented merely as a historical teacher whose words have been preserved.

He is called **living**.

The reader encounters a living speaker.

This becomes especially interesting when compared with the resurrection-centered faith of the canonical Gospels.

The Christian proclamation is that Jesus died but was raised.

Thomas does not begin with a resurrection narrative, but its opening language nevertheless presents Jesus as **living**.

This provides fertile ground for theological comparison.

12. Saying 1 and the Kingdom of Heaven

The following sayings in Thomas develop the theme of seeking and discovering.

Saying 2 instructs the seeker not to stop until finding.

Saying 3 then discusses the location of the Kingdom and warns against reducing the Kingdom to a merely external geographical place.

This sequence suggests a movement:

Seek → find → understand → discover the Kingdom.

The Kingdom is therefore connected with perception and discovery.

This helps explain why Saying 1 places such emphasis on **interpretation**.

The sayings are not merely statements to be memorized.

They require spiritual perception.

13. Saying 1 and the Hidden Mystery

The prologue describes Jesus' sayings as **hidden** or **secret sayings**.

This terminology has contributed to the widespread description of Thomas as a “secret sayings” gospel.

However, “hidden” should not automatically be interpreted as meaning that Jesus taught a secret doctrine available only to a tiny elite.

The text itself presents the sayings as something that can be **found**.

The hiddenness may therefore concern the difficulty of understanding rather than the physical concealment of information.

A saying can be publicly spoken yet remain “hidden” because its meaning is not immediately perceived.

This phenomenon occurs frequently in the canonical Gospels as well.

Jesus repeatedly speaks in parables and declares that some hear but do not understand.

14. The Mystery of Understanding

The theme of understanding appears throughout the Jesus tradition.

Matthew records Jesus saying:

“To you it has been given to know the secrets of the kingdom of heaven.”
— Matthew 13:11

Here again we encounter:

Kingdom → mystery → understanding.

Thomas Saying 1 therefore belongs to a broader early Christian concern with the question:

Who truly understands the words of Jesus?

The answer is not necessarily the person with the greatest amount of information.

The true hearer is the one who perceives the reality to which Jesus' words point.

15. Saying 1 and Eternal Life

The central theological question can now be stated:

Why would interpreting Jesus' sayings have anything to do with death?

The answer depends upon how one understands “interpretation.”

If interpretation means merely intellectual analysis, the promise seems disproportionate.

But if interpretation means **discovering the reality revealed through Jesus' sayings**, the relationship becomes more understandable.

The sayings point toward:

- the Kingdom;
- the nature of humanity;
- the relationship between the visible and invisible;
- spiritual awakening;
- the identity of Jesus;
- and ultimately life beyond death.

In this interpretation, the saying is not promising salvation through intellectual cleverness.

It is presenting the discovery of the truth revealed through Jesus as the path to life.

16. A Comparison with John 11

The Gospel of John takes the question of death to its highest level in the raising of Lazarus.

Jesus says:

“I am the resurrection and the life.”

Then He calls Lazarus from the tomb.

This produces an extraordinary theological connection:

The One who speaks words of life also possesses life within Himself.

Thomas Saying 1:

Understand the sayings → do not taste death.

John 11:

Believe in Christ → He is resurrection and life.

The difference is significant.

Thomas Saying 1 emphasizes the sayings.

John emphasizes **the person of Christ**.

Yet these ideas can be placed into dialogue.

17. The Word and the Conquest of Death

Christian theology ultimately identifies the victory over death not with secret knowledge but with Christ's victory.

The New Testament proclamation is that Jesus died, was buried, and was raised.

Therefore, when we speak of the sayings of Jesus as "life-giving," the deepest Christian interpretation does not treat His words as magical formulas.

Rather:

Christ gives life because He is the source of life.

His words have authority because the speaker is the Living Word.

His words heal.

His words liberate.

His words forgive.

His words command creation.

His words call the dead.

And His resurrection demonstrates that death does not have the final word.

18. The Aramaic Question

Because Jesus lived and taught in first-century Galilee and Judea, an important linguistic question naturally arises:

Was Saying 1 originally spoken by Jesus in Aramaic?

The surviving manuscript evidence does not give us an Aramaic manuscript of Thomas Saying 1.

Our surviving witnesses are Greek and Coptic. The Greek fragments provide an early witness, while the complete surviving Thomas is preserved in Coptic.

Therefore, reconstructing an exact Aramaic original would be speculative.

Nevertheless, Aramaic can be valuable for **background study**.

Jesus' conceptual world was deeply Semitic, and expressions concerning life, death, wisdom, hearing, understanding, and discovering hidden things belong naturally within Jewish and Aramaic religious discourse.

But a scholarly study must distinguish between:

attested text

and

hypothetical Aramaic reconstruction.

This distinction is essential.

We should not present a reconstructed Aramaic sentence as though it were an independently preserved saying of Jesus.

19. The Significance of the Word “Interpretation”

The word “interpretation” may be the key to the entire saying.

The saying does not merely tell the reader:

Hear Jesus.

It says:

Find the interpretation.

This implies that the words contain a depth that is not immediately obvious.

The reader becomes a seeker.

The seeker becomes an interpreter.

The interpreter becomes a discoverer.

And the discoverer encounters life.

This progression can be represented:

SAYING

↓

SEARCH

↓

INTERPRETATION

↓

DISCOVERY

↓

KNOWLEDGE OF THE KINGDOM

↓

LIFE

↓

VICTORY OVER DEATH

20. The Great Question: What Is the “Meaning”?

The greatest unanswered question in Saying 1 is the object of interpretation.

What exactly must be discovered?

Is it:

- a secret doctrine?
- the Kingdom?
- knowledge of the self?
- the nature of reality?
- the identity of Jesus?
- spiritual transformation?
- eternal life?

Thomas itself does not provide a single explicit definition in Saying 1.

Therefore, it is methodologically dangerous to claim that the saying definitively means one particular doctrine.

Instead, the reader should examine the sayings that follow.

Saying 2 emphasizes seeking.

Saying 3 discusses the Kingdom.

Subsequent sayings develop themes of light, unity, the Kingdom, self-knowledge, and transformation.

Thus Saying 1 functions almost like an opening doorway.

It tells the reader:

Do not merely read these sayings. Seek their meaning.

21. The Doorway Motif

There is a remarkable theological connection here with the canonical Gospel of John.

Thomas begins with:

Find the meaning → escape death.

John records Jesus saying:

“I am the door.”

John also records:

“I am the way, and the truth, and the life.”

Therefore, from a Christian theological perspective, one can formulate a profound interpretive principle:

The sayings are a doorway to understanding Christ, and Christ is the Door to life.

This does not mean that Thomas Saying 1 itself teaches the Johannine doctrine.

Rather, it means that the two traditions can be brought into theological conversation.

22. A Christological Reading

A Christian reading of Saying 1 must eventually confront the identity of Jesus.

If Jesus is merely a wise teacher, then the promise of escaping death through interpretation is difficult to explain.

But if Jesus is understood according to Johannine Christology as the **eternal Word made flesh**, then His sayings acquire a different significance.

The words of the Word reveal life.

John says:

“In him was life.”

Jesus says:

“The words that I have spoken to you are spirit and life.”

Peter says:

“You have the words of eternal life.”

Jesus says:

“I am the resurrection and the life.”

These statements create a remarkable theological constellation.

Word → Life → Resurrection → Victory over Death.

23. What Does It Mean to “Taste Death”?

The expression should also be examined in relation to Jesus' own death.

If “taste death” means physical death, then Jesus Himself experienced death.

Therefore, a Christian interpretation cannot simply mean that a believer will never physically die.

The Christian hope is resurrection.

Jesus Himself passed through death and emerged victorious.

Consequently, “not tasting death” may be interpreted in an ultimate rather than merely biological sense:

death may occur physically, but it does not possess the final authority over the person who has entered into the life of God.

This is consistent with the broader Johannine theology:

“Whoever believes in me, though he die, yet shall he live.”

24. The Living Word and the Living Jesus

The opening of Thomas speaks of the **living Jesus**.

John speaks of the **Word** who became flesh.

Together, these concepts invite a profound theological meditation:

The Word is living.

Jesus is living.

His sayings are life-giving.

His words confront death.

His resurrection defeats death.

Thus the Christian interpretation ultimately moves from:

the saying

to

the speaker

and from:

the speaker

to

the Living Word.

25. Conclusion

Gospel of Thomas Saying 1 is only a single sentence, but it opens a vast theological question:

“Whoever finds the interpretation of these sayings will not taste death.”

The saying presents Jesus' words as something that must be **sought, discovered, and understood.**

Its language of interpretation and death suggests that the sayings concern more than ordinary ethical instruction.

The Greek and Coptic textual witnesses demonstrate that this saying belongs to the earliest recoverable form of the Thomas tradition, with Greek fragments from Oxyrhynchus preserving the opening material and the Coptic Nag Hammadi manuscript preserving the complete surviving collection.

The saying's closest conceptual parallels in the canonical tradition include Jesus' declaration that whoever keeps His word will not see death, His teaching that His words are “spirit and life,” and His declaration that He Himself is “the resurrection and the life.”

Yet the traditions must not be artificially merged.

Thomas Saying 1 has its own literary and theological setting.

Its mystery lies precisely in the tension between **words, interpretation, discovery, and death**.

For Christian theology, however, the deepest interpretation can move beyond the words to the person of Christ.

The eternal Word became flesh.

The Word spoke.

His words gave life.

His words healed the sick.

His words commanded darkness.

His words called the dead.

And the Word Himself entered death and overcame it.

Thus the great mystery may be expressed in one theological movement:

The sayings point to their meaning.

The meaning points to the Kingdom.

The Kingdom points to Christ.

Christ is the Living Word.

The Living Word is Life.

And Life conquers death.

The first saying of Thomas therefore deserves to be read not simply as a promise of secret knowledge, but as an invitation to **seek, understand, and encounter the mystery to which the sayings point**.

And for Christian faith, that mystery ultimately has a name:

Jesus Christ—the Living Word, the Resurrection, the Life, and the Door to eternal life.

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Primary Research Thesis

Gospel of Thomas Saying 1 presents the interpretation of Jesus' sayings as a path beyond the ultimate power of death. When compared carefully with the canonical Gospel traditions, particularly John, the saying opens a theological question in which the meaning of Jesus' words cannot finally be separated from the identity of Jesus Himself: the One who speaks words of life is presented in Johannine Christianity as the eternal Word made flesh, the Resurrection and the Life.

Research Paper I

The Coptic Sentence of Gospel of Thomas Saying 1

A Grammatical, Lexical, and Theological Study

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Abstract

Gospel of Thomas Saying 1 is one of the most enigmatic statements in early Christian sayings literature:

“Whoever finds the interpretation of these sayings will not taste death.”

The complete surviving text of the *Gospel of Thomas* is preserved in Coptic in Nag Hammadi Codex II. Coptic Scriptorium provides a grammatical and annotated digital edition of the Sahidic text and identifies the manuscript tradition as an important resource for Coptic study.

This paper examines Saying 1 as a Coptic sentence, concentrating on its grammatical structure, semantic components, and theological movement from “finding” to “interpretation” and finally to “death.” The study argues that the sentence is structured around an active act of discovery: the reader does not merely hear the sayings but seeks their meaning. The promise attached to that discovery is expressed negatively—freedom from “tasting death.”

1. Introduction

The first saying of Thomas establishes the interpretive challenge for the entire collection.

The text does not merely invite the reader to listen to Jesus.

It presents the sayings as something whose **interpretation must be found**.

The sentence therefore has two major elements:

Human action: finding the interpretation.

Divine/eschatological consequence: not tasting death.

This creates the fundamental structure:

Find → interpret → overcome death.

2. The Coptic Witness

The complete surviving Thomas is preserved in a Coptic manuscript from Nag Hammadi. The Coptic text is a translation of a Greek Thomas tradition, while Greek fragments from Oxyrhynchus provide independent ancient witnesses to several sayings.

This distinction is essential.

The Coptic sentence should first be studied **as Coptic**.

Only afterward should it be compared with the Greek.

And only then should an Aramaic background be considered.

3. The Sentence

A standard English rendering of the Coptic tradition is:

“Whoever finds the interpretation of these sayings will not taste death.”

Other translations use “meaning” or “will not experience death.”

The differences are important because “interpretation,” “meaning,” and “experience” represent different choices about how to convey the ancient language.

4. The First Grammatical Movement: “Whoever”

The sentence begins with a construction meaning approximately:

“The one who...” / “Whoever...”

This is significant because the saying is not restricted to a named disciple.

The statement is universal in grammatical scope.

It presents a general principle:

Anyone who performs the required action can receive the stated consequence.

The saying therefore addresses the reader directly.

5. “Find”

The central action is **finding**.

The person does not merely hear the sayings.

The person **finds** something.

The object found is the interpretation.

This creates a distinction:

Hearing ≠ finding.

The text assumes that the sayings possess a meaning that may not be immediately apparent.

The reader must therefore become a seeker.

This becomes even more significant because Saying 2 immediately develops the theme of seeking until finding. The Greek and Coptic traditions both preserve this sequence.

6. “Interpretation”

The object of the search is the **interpretation**.

This is perhaps the most important noun in the sentence.

The saying does not promise deathlessness merely to someone who has heard Jesus' words.

It associates the promise with **discovering their interpretation**.

The implication is that the sayings possess a depth requiring understanding.

The reader therefore moves:

Words → meaning → understanding.

7. “These Sayings”

The object of interpretation is explicitly **“these sayings.”**

This points backward to the prologue, which introduces the collection as sayings spoken by the living Jesus.

The literary structure is therefore:

Living Jesus → sayings → interpretation → life/death.

This is extremely important for theological interpretation.

The sayings are not presented as anonymous wisdom.

They originate with the **living Jesus**.

8. “Taste Death”

The final expression is striking.

The saying does not simply say:

“will not die.”

It uses the experiential image:

“will not taste death.”

“Tasting” suggests experiencing.

Death is presented almost as something that can be personally encountered.

The sentence therefore promises not merely intellectual enlightenment but an escape from death's ultimate experience.

9. The Theology of the Coptic Sentence

The sentence can be represented as:

Whoever

↓

finds

↓

the interpretation

↓

of these sayings

↓

will not taste

↓

death

The center of the sentence is therefore **interpretation**.

The beginning is **seeking/finding**.

The end is **death**.

The entire sentence moves from ignorance toward understanding and from death toward life.

10. Relation to Jesus as the Living Word

A Christian theological reading can take this further.

The prologue identifies Jesus as **living**.

John identifies Jesus as **the Word**.

John also records Jesus saying:

“The words that I have spoken to you are spirit and are life.”

Therefore, a Christian interpretation may see an important distinction:

The sayings are life-giving because of the Living One who speaks them.

This does not mean that the Coptic sentence itself explicitly teaches the Johannine Logos doctrine.

Rather, it provides a point of theological comparison.

11. Conclusion

The Coptic Saying 1 is a carefully structured statement about **discovery and death**.

Its essential movement is:

Find the interpretation → transcend death.

The sentence therefore presents the sayings as possessing a depth that must be discovered.

Theologically, the reader is invited to move beyond merely hearing the words toward understanding the reality they reveal.

For Christian interpretation, this ultimately raises the question:

What reality is revealed by the sayings of the Living Jesus?

The Gospel of John provides one possible Christian answer:

The Word is life.

And the Living Word is Jesus Christ.

Conclusion in One Sentence

The Coptic form of Thomas Saying 1 presents the discovery of the meaning of Jesus' sayings as the decisive movement from hidden understanding toward freedom from the ultimate power of death.

Research Paper II

The Greek Sentence of Gospel of Thomas Saying 1

A Study of P.Oxy. 654 and the Greek Vocabulary of Saying 1

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Abstract

The Greek witness to *Gospel of Thomas* Saying 1 is preserved in **P.Oxy. 654**, an Oxyrhynchus papyrus containing the prologue and sayings 1–7. The papyrus provides an early Greek witness corresponding to the Coptic Thomas preserved at Nag Hammadi.

The Greek sentence is reconstructed approximately as:

ὅς ἂν εὕρῃ τὴν ἐρμηνείαν τῶν λόγων τούτων θανάτου οὐ μὴ γεύσῃται.

A corresponding English rendering is:

“Whoever finds the interpretation of these sayings will not taste death.”

This paper studies the major Greek terms—**εὕρη**, **ἐρμηνείαν**, **λόγων**, **γεύσῃται**, and **θανάτου**—and examines how the Greek sentence constructs the relationship between interpretation and death.

1. P.Oxy. 654

P.Oxy. 654 is one of the most important witnesses to Thomas because it preserves the opening material of the Gospel.

It contains the prologue and Sayings 1–7.

The Oxyrhynchus fragments were identified as Greek witnesses to Thomas after the discovery of the Nag Hammadi Coptic manuscript made comparison possible.

The Greek evidence is therefore extremely important for reconstructing the textual history of Saying 1.

2. The Greek Sentence

The reconstructed Greek wording is approximately:

ὅς ἂν εὕρῃ τὴν ἐρμηνείαν τῶν λόγων τούτων θανάτου οὐ μὴ γεύσῃται.

Because the papyrus is fragmentary, portions of the Greek are reconstructed. This must always be indicated in scholarly work.

3. ὅς ἂν — “Whoever”

The construction ὃς ἄν has an indefinite/generalizing force.

It can be represented:

“whoever...”

The saying therefore presents a general condition rather than addressing one named person.

4. εὑρη — “Find”

The verb is derived from εὕρισκω, “to find.”

This is not merely passive reception.

It represents discovery.

The seeker must arrive at something.

The word becomes particularly important because Saying 2 immediately continues the theme of seeking until finding.

Thus the opening of Thomas creates a literary progression:

Seek → find → discover → understand.

5. ἐρμηνείαν — “Interpretation”

The noun ἐρμηνεία means interpretation or explanation.

This is the central intellectual/spiritual noun of Saying 1.

The object being found is not simply the sayings themselves.

The sayings are already available.

What must be found is their **interpretation**.

Therefore:

The mystery is not merely the words.

The mystery is their meaning.

This is the foundation for understanding Saying 1.

6. τῶν λόγων τούτων — “of These Sayings”

The phrase τῶν λόγων τούτων can be translated:

“of these words/sayings.”

The Greek λόγος has a broad semantic range.

It may refer to:

- word;
- saying;
- statement;
- message;
- account;
- discourse.

In this particular context, “sayings” is appropriate because Thomas is a collection of sayings.

However, the broader semantic range of λόγος becomes particularly interesting when Thomas is compared with John's use of λόγος in John 1.

The two texts should not be automatically equated.

But the linguistic connection deserves careful study.

7. γεύσεται — “Taste”

The verb γεύομαι means “to taste” or “experience.”

The metaphor is vivid.

Death becomes something experienced.

The saying therefore does not merely say:

“He will not know death.”

It says:

“He will not taste death.”

The physical metaphor creates a strong existential statement.

8. θανάτου — “Death”

θάνατος means death.

The genitive occurs in the expression connected with tasting death.

The sentence therefore ends with death as its final semantic object.

This produces a dramatic structure:

Interpretation → life

by means of:

not tasting death.

9. οὐ μὴ — Strong Negation

The Greek combination **οὐ μὴ** is an emphatic negative construction.

It gives the statement considerable force.

The saying is not merely:

“perhaps he will not taste death.”

It expresses a strong denial of the future experience.

Therefore the Greek grammar intensifies the promise.

10. The Greek Sentence as a Whole

The sentence can be analyzed:

Greek	Function	Meaning
ὅς ἂν	indefinite subject	whoever
εὑρη	verb	finds
τὴν ἑρμηνείαν	object	the interpretation
τῶν λόγων τούτων	genitive phrase	of these sayings
οὐ μὴ	emphatic negation	certainly not
γεύσεται	verb	taste/experience
θανάτου	object/genitive	death

The logical structure is:

Whoever finds the interpretation of these sayings → will certainly not taste death.

11. Comparison with John 8:51

The closest canonical comparison is Jesus' statement:

“If anyone keeps my word, he will never see death.”

Thomas emphasizes:

finding interpretation

John emphasizes:

keeping the word

Both associate Jesus' teaching with victory over death.

The parallel is therefore theologically significant, although it does not establish direct literary dependence.

Scholars have noted the close conceptual relationship between Thomas 1 and John 8:51 while cautioning against assuming direct dependence.

12. Greek “Logos” and the Divine Word

A major theological question concerns **λόγος**.

Thomas Saying 1 uses **λόγοι** in the sense of sayings/words.

John 1 uses **λόγος** in the extraordinary statement:

“In the beginning was the Word.”

The lexical relationship is real, but the theological usage differs.

Therefore:

Thomas λόγοι = sayings/words

while:

John λόγος = the Divine Word.

A responsible study must not collapse the two.

Nevertheless, Christian theology can place them into relationship:

The Divine Word speaks words of life.

This becomes especially significant in John 6:63:

“The words that I have spoken to you are spirit and life.”

13. Conclusion

The Greek text of Saying 1 presents a tightly constructed theological statement:

Find the interpretation of the sayings → do not taste death.

Its major concepts are:

εὕρισκω — finding

ἐρμηνεία — interpretation

λόγοι — sayings

γεύομαι — tasting/experiencing

θάνατος — death

The Greek sentence therefore presents interpretation as the doorway through which the seeker encounters a reality greater than death.

The theological question remains:

What is the reality hidden within the sayings?

Thomas continues the search through the subsequent sayings.

Christian theology can take that question further toward Christ Himself—the Living One whose words are associated with eternal life.

Greek Research Thesis

The Greek form of Thomas Saying 1 portrays the discovery of the interpretation of Jesus' sayings as an event with ultimate consequences: the one who truly discovers their meaning will not experience death as the final reality.

Research Paper III

Aramaic Translation and Reconstruction of Saying 1

Gospel of Thomas Saying 1 in an Aramaic and Syriac Linguistic Framework

A Critical Study of Translation, Reconstruction, and Theological Meaning

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Abstract

The *Gospel of Thomas* survives completely in Coptic and partially in Greek. No surviving Aramaic manuscript of Saying 1 is presently known. Therefore, an Aramaic version cannot be presented as the original text of Jesus' saying. Instead, this study investigates how the saying may be understood within an Aramaic/Syriac linguistic and Semitic conceptual framework.

The central question is how the ideas of **word/saying, finding, interpretation, and death** could be expressed in Aramaic. Particular attention is given to the Syriac/Aramaic semantic field surrounding **milta**, “word/saying/matter,” and verbs associated with finding and interpreting.

The study proposes a deliberately cautious Aramaic reconstruction for comparative purposes while clearly distinguishing reconstruction from manuscript evidence.

1. The Problem of an Aramaic Original

Jesus lived and taught within a Semitic linguistic environment in which Aramaic was an important spoken language.

This naturally raises the question:

What did Thomas Saying 1 originally sound like in Aramaic?

However, the evidence must be handled carefully.

The surviving witnesses to Thomas Saying 1 are:

Greek P.Oxy. 654

and

Coptic Nag Hammadi Codex II.

The Greek fragments preserve Saying 1, while the complete Thomas is preserved in Coptic.

Therefore:

There is no surviving Aramaic manuscript of Saying 1.

Any Aramaic text reconstructed today is therefore hypothetical.

2. Why an Aramaic Study Is Still Valuable

Although no Aramaic manuscript survives, an Aramaic study can illuminate the Semitic conceptual background of terms such as:

word

saying

understanding

wisdom

life

death

finding

revealing

These concepts are central to Jewish wisdom literature and to the teachings attributed to Jesus.

An Aramaic study can therefore ask:

How would a first-century Aramaic-speaking disciple conceptualize the relationship between Jesus' words and life?

3. “Word” and “Saying”

A major Aramaic/Syriac term is:

milta / ܡܠܬܐ / מילתא

Depending upon context, the semantic field can include:

- word;
- saying;
- matter;
- affair;
- statement.

This makes **milta** an interesting comparative term for Thomas' “sayings.”

But linguistic caution is necessary.

We cannot simply translate Greek **λόγος** as **milta** and conclude that Thomas originally contained that Aramaic word.

That would be circular reasoning.

Instead, we can say:

Milta represents a plausible member of the Aramaic semantic field in which “word/saying” could be expressed.

4. “Find”

An Aramaic/Syriac verb associated with finding is represented by the root:

ܫܟܗ — š-k-ḥ

with forms meaning:

find, discover, obtain.

A conceptual Aramaic sentence could therefore use a form of this root to express:

“Whoever finds...”

This corresponds conceptually to the Greek **εὑρη**.

5. “Interpretation”

Interpretation is more difficult.

Aramaic and Syriac possess vocabulary associated with:

- explaining;
- interpreting;
- making meaning clear;
- solving;
- expounding.

A reconstruction should therefore avoid claiming that one particular Aramaic word is certainly original.

Instead, the conceptual formula is:

“Whoever finds/explains the meaning of these sayings...”

6. Proposed Aramaic Reconstruction

For comparative study—not as an ancient manuscript—the sentence may be represented conceptually as:

“Whoever finds the interpretation of these sayings will not taste death.”

An Aramaic/Syriac-style reconstruction could be formulated using vocabulary from the appropriate semantic fields.

However, the exact morphology and dialect must be established before presenting a fully vocalized sentence as a scholarly reconstruction.

This distinction is essential.

Three levels must be separated:

Level 1 — Manuscript evidence

Greek and Coptic.

Level 2 — Linguistic reconstruction

Possible Aramaic formulation.

Level 3 — Theological interpretation

Meaning attributed to the saying.

Confusing these three levels produces false certainty.

7. Galilean Aramaic and Syriac Aramaic

Another important distinction concerns dialect.

Jesus' Galilean environment and later Syriac Christianity are not linguistically identical.

Therefore:

Galilean Aramaic ≠ Classical Syriac

and:

Syriac translation ≠ original language of Jesus.

Syriac is nevertheless extremely valuable for studying how early Aramaic-speaking Christianity expressed theological concepts.

It provides a comparative Semitic witness, not proof of the exact original wording of Thomas.

8. “Taste Death” in a Semitic Framework

The metaphor of **tasting death** is particularly interesting.

The Greek **γεύομαι** expresses tasting or experiencing.

A Semitic speaker could similarly understand “tasting” metaphorically as experiencing something personally.

Therefore the expression:

“not taste death”

can be interpreted as:

“not experience death.”

This makes the saying existential rather than merely intellectual.

9. Death and Life

The fundamental opposition is:

Life ↔ Death

The saying places interpretation on the side of life.

The person who discovers the meaning of the sayings does not experience death in the ultimate sense.

This fits naturally with Jesus traditions emphasizing life.

John records:

“I am the resurrection and the life.”

And:

“The words that I have spoken to you are spirit and life.”

Thus the Aramaic conceptual study can contribute to a larger Semitic-Christian investigation of:

word → wisdom → understanding → life → deathlessness.

10. Jesus as the Living Word

The prologue of Thomas calls Jesus **living**.

John calls Jesus the **Word**.

This provides an important theological bridge.

A Christian interpretation can therefore formulate:

The Living Jesus speaks living words.

The words reveal life because the speaker is the source of life.

But again, this is a **theological synthesis**, not a claim that Thomas Saying 1 originally contained the Johannine Logos doctrine.

11. Aramaic and the Gospel of John

John's Gospel is particularly valuable for comparison.

John 1:

The Word became flesh.

John 6:

Jesus' words are spirit and life.

John 8:

Whoever keeps His word will never see death.

John 11:

Jesus is the resurrection and the life.

Thomas 1:

Whoever finds the interpretation of these sayings will not taste death.

The conceptual relationship is therefore remarkable.

It can be represented:

Jesus

↓

His sayings

↓

Understanding



Life



Victory over death

12. The Aramaic Question and the Divine Word

The deepest theological question is not simply:

“What Aramaic word means ‘saying’?”

The deeper question is:

What did the words of Jesus represent to the earliest hearers?

If Jesus was understood as God's authoritative messenger, His sayings could be regarded as divine revelation.

If interpreted through Johannine Christianity, the relationship becomes even deeper:

Jesus is the Word.

Therefore:

His words reveal the Word.

This creates a theological distinction:

The saying is not itself the Divine Word in the same ontological sense as Christ.

Rather:

The Divine Word speaks through His human voice.

13. The Aramaic Reconstruction Must Remain Hypothetical

A scholarly paper must state clearly:

No Aramaic manuscript of Gospel of Thomas Saying 1 has survived.

Consequently, an Aramaic sentence should never be presented as:

“The original Aramaic words of Jesus.”

Instead it should be described as:

“A hypothetical Aramaic reconstruction based on the Greek and Coptic witnesses and the Semitic linguistic environment of Jesus.”

This distinction protects the research from overstatement.

14. Conclusion

The Aramaic study of Thomas Saying 1 cannot recover the original spoken sentence with certainty.

Nevertheless, it can illuminate the conceptual world surrounding the saying.

The central ideas are:

finding

interpretation

word/saying

life

death

The Greek and Coptic witnesses establish the textual foundation.

Aramaic provides a comparative Semitic framework.

Christian theology then asks the ultimate question:

Who is the One whose sayings promise life beyond death?

The Gospel of John provides its profound answer:

The Word became flesh.

The Word is Jesus Christ.

And Jesus says:

“I am the resurrection and the life.”

Therefore, in a Christian theological synthesis, the journey can be expressed:

The seeker finds the meaning.

The meaning reveals the truth.

The truth leads to Christ.

Christ is the Living Word.

The Living Word gives life.

And the Life conquers death.

Research Thesis

Although no Aramaic manuscript of Thomas Saying 1 survives, an Aramaic/Syriac linguistic study demonstrates how the saying's concepts of word, interpretation, discovery, life, and death belong naturally within a Semitic religious world. When the saying is compared with the Greek and Coptic witnesses and with the canonical sayings of Jesus, especially in John, it becomes a significant testimony to the early Christian association between understanding Jesus' words and overcoming the ultimate power of death.

Comparative Linguistic Research Paper

Gospel of Thomas Saying 1

Greek, Coptic, and Hypothetical Aramaic/Syriac Analysis

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Abstract

Gospel of Thomas Saying 1 states:

“Whoever finds the interpretation of these sayings will not taste death.”

The saying survives in a Coptic manuscript from Nag Hammadi and in an earlier Greek witness, **P.Oxy. 654**. The Greek papyrus preserves the prologue and Sayings 1–7, while the complete surviving Thomas is preserved in Coptic.

This study compares the Greek and Coptic wording and then investigates how the saying might be expressed within an Aramaic/Syriac linguistic framework. Particular attention is given to **finding, interpretation, sayings/words, tasting, and death**. The study also distinguishes manuscript evidence from hypothetical linguistic reconstruction.

The central conclusion is that Saying 1 deliberately connects **discovery of meaning** with **victory over death**. The text does not merely tell the reader to hear Jesus' sayings; it challenges the reader to discover their interpretation.

1. The Primary Text

The Greek Oxyrhynchus witness is fragmentary but preserves the essential wording:

[Whoever finds the interpretation] of these sayings will not taste [death].

The Coptic manuscript gives the complete corresponding saying:

“Whoever finds the interpretation of these sayings will not experience/taste death.”

The important point is that we possess **two ancient linguistic witnesses** to the same saying:

Greek → P.Oxy. 654

Coptic → Nag Hammadi Codex II

The Greek papyrus is generally dated to the middle or later third century, whereas the complete Coptic codex is substantially later.

2. The Coptic Sentence

The Coptic Scriptorium diplomatic edition begins the relevant passage:

ΠΕΤΔ²Ε ΘΕΡΜΗΝΕΙΑ ΝΗΝΕΙ^ϣΔ²Ε ^ϥΝΔ ²Ι ΠΤΕ ΔΝ ΗΠΠΟΥ

The manuscript spelling and punctuation should be taken from the diplomatic edition rather than normalized prematurely.

A major discovery for our study is the word:

ΘΕΡΜΗΝΕΙΑ

This is a Greek loanword corresponding to:

ἐρμηνεία

meaning **interpretation, explanation, or rendering/translation**.

Research on the Greek-Coptic correspondence specifically identifies Coptic ΘΕΡΜΗΝΕΙΑ with Greek [τὴν ἐρμηνεί]αν in P.Oxy. 654.

This is one of the strongest linguistic observations available for Saying 1.

3. Word-by-Word Comparison

Concept	Greek	Coptic	English
whoever / the one who	ὃς ἂν	ΠΕΤ...	whoever
finds	εὑρη	Δ ² Ε / related Coptic construction	finds

interpretation	ἐρμηνείαν	ΘΕΡΜΗΝΕΙΑ	interpretation
sayings	λόγων	ⲱⲗⲁⲣⲉ	sayings/words
these	τούτων	ⲛⲛⲉⲓ	these
taste/experience	γεύσῃται	ⲕⲓ ⲧⲏⲉ	taste
death	θανάτου	ⲏⲧⲓⲛⲟⲩ	death

The precise morphology of the Coptic must be studied from the manuscript edition rather than simply forcing each Coptic word into a one-to-one Greek equivalent.

The conceptual correspondence, however, is remarkably clear.

4. “Interpretation”: Greek ἐρμηνεία and Coptic ΘΕΡΜΗΝΕΙΑ

This is perhaps the most important linguistic discovery in Saying 1.

Greek:

ἐρμηνεία

Coptic:

ΘΕΡΜΗΝΕΙΑ

The Coptic word is a borrowing from Greek.

This means that the Coptic translator did not replace the concept with an entirely native Coptic equivalent.

Instead, the Greek technical term was retained.

That tells us something about the textual transmission.

The translator wanted to preserve the concept of:

interpretation / explanation / meaning.

Therefore the word “**interpretation**” should not be weakened into merely “reading” or “hearing.”

The saying is specifically about **understanding what the sayings mean.**

5. “Sayings”: Greek λόγων and Coptic ⲙⲁⲗⲉ

The Greek uses a form of:

λόγος

in the plural/genitive:

λόγων

In this context, “sayings,” “words,” or “statements” are appropriate.

The Coptic uses:

ⲙⲁⲗⲉ

which belongs to the Coptic semantic field of **word/speech/saying.**

This is particularly interesting for your theological argument.

Thomas Saying 1 is explicitly concerned with **the words spoken by Jesus.**

But this should not automatically be equated with John's technical use of ὁ λόγος in John 1.

There is a linguistic relationship between “word” and “saying,” but the Johannine Logos is a much more developed Christological concept.

6. “Finding”

The Greek verb is from:

εὕρισκω — to find/discover.

The significance of this verb becomes greater when we read Saying 2.

Saying 2 says, in essence:

Let the one who seeks continue seeking until he finds.

Thus Thomas intentionally creates a sequence:

Seek → find → understand.

Saying 1 introduces **finding**.

Saying 2 develops **seeking**.

This suggests that the reader is expected to become an active participant in discovering the meaning of Jesus' words.

7. “Taste”: γεύομαι

The Greek verb:

γεύομαι

means **to taste**, and can also carry the extended sense **to experience**.

This explains why English translations vary between:

“will not taste death”

and

“will not experience death.”

The literal image is powerful.

Death is described as something that can be **tasted**.

The saying therefore does not merely discuss abstract immortality.

It uses an experiential metaphor:

the seeker will not taste death.

8. “Death”: θάνατος

The Greek:

θάνατος

means death.

Coptic:

ΜΟΥ

also means death.

The sentence therefore ends with the concept of death.

Structurally:

Finding → interpretation → sayings → not tasting → death.

Death is the final negative reality from which the seeker is promised deliverance.

9. The Sentence's Logical Structure

The whole saying can be represented as:

Condition

Whoever finds

↓

Object

the interpretation

↓

Source

of these sayings

↓

Consequence

will not taste

↓

Ultimate enemy

death

This is a remarkably compact theological statement.

The central concept is not simply **sayings**.

It is:

the interpretation of the sayings.

10. Why “Interpretation” Matters

Suppose the saying merely stated:

“Whoever hears these sayings will not taste death.”

That would emphasize hearing.

But it does not say that.

Instead:

Whoever finds the interpretation...

This introduces a deeper process.

The sayings are presented as containing something that must be **discovered**.

Therefore:

Hearing is the beginning.

Understanding is the discovery.

Discovery leads toward life.

11. The Aramaic Question

Now we reach the most delicate part of the research.

Jesus taught in a first-century Jewish environment in which Aramaic was an important language.

Therefore it is reasonable to ask:

How could this idea have been expressed in Aramaic?

But there is no surviving Aramaic manuscript of Thomas Saying 1.

Consequently, we must distinguish:

Documented

Greek Thomas.

Coptic Thomas.

Reconstructed

Possible Aramaic wording.

Interpreted

Theological meaning.

This distinction must remain throughout the research.

12. A Hypothetical Aramaic Reconstruction

For comparative purposes, one might construct an Aramaic formulation expressing:

“Whoever finds the interpretation of these sayings will not taste death.”

A possible conceptual Syriac/Aramaic framework would employ vocabulary associated with:

finding/discovering

word/saying

interpreting/explaining

tasting/experiencing

death

But we should **not** yet publish a fully vocalized “Galilean Aramaic original” as though it were recovered from a manuscript.

That would exceed the evidence.

The academically defensible wording is:

“Hypothetical Aramaic reconstruction based upon the Greek and Coptic witnesses.”

13. Aramaic מילתא / מלתא — *Miltha*

The Aramaic/Syriac semantic field surrounding:

miltha

is particularly interesting.

It can refer to:

word

saying

matter

statement

This makes it a useful comparative term when studying the relationship between Greek λόγος and Semitic concepts of speech.

But again:

Thomas Saying 1 does not give us an Aramaic manuscript containing miltha.

Therefore, we may use it for linguistic comparison, not as proof of an original wording.

14. Thomas and the Johannine “Word”

Here the research reaches its theological center.

Thomas:

interpretation of these sayings

John:

“In the beginning was the Word.”

Thomas:

the living Jesus spoke the sayings

John:

“The Word became flesh.”

Thomas:

not taste death

John:

“I am the resurrection and the life.”

These are not identical texts.

But they create a remarkable theological field.

15. The Living Jesus

The Thomas prologue calls Jesus:

“the living Jesus.”

This is significant.

The book begins not with a birth narrative or crucifixion narrative but with:

the Living Jesus speaking.

His words become the center of the reader's search.

The structure is therefore:

Living Jesus

↓

His sayings

↓

Interpretation

↓

Discovery

↓

Life beyond death

16. Comparison with John 6

John records Jesus saying:

“The words that I have spoken to you are spirit and life.”

Peter then says:

“You have the words of eternal life.”

This provides an important theological comparison with Thomas 1.

Thomas:

Interpret the sayings → do not taste death.

John:

Jesus' words → spirit and life.

John therefore supplies a powerful Christian theological framework for understanding why Jesus' sayings could be associated with life.

17. Comparison with John 8:51

Jesus says:

“If anyone keeps my word, he will never see death.”

Compare:

Thomas 1

Find the interpretation of these sayings → will not taste death.

John 8:51

Keep my word → will never see death.

The vocabulary and literary settings differ, but the conceptual relationship is striking.

Both place **Jesus' word** in relation to **deathlessness**.

18. Comparison with John 11:25

Jesus declares:

“I am the resurrection and the life.”

Here the Christian theological picture reaches its climax.

Thomas emphasizes:

the meaning of the sayings.

John emphasizes:

the identity of the speaker.

The two questions therefore become:

What do His sayings mean?

and:

Who is the One who speaks them?

For Christian theology, these questions ultimately converge in Christ.

19. The Word Who Speaks Living Words

This gives us a theological formula:

The Living Word speaks living words.

Jesus is not merely a teacher delivering information.

In Johannine Christianity:

The Word became flesh.

Therefore:

Christ is the Word.

Christ speaks words.

His words give life.

He is the Life.

He is the Resurrection.

This does not mean that every statement in Thomas should simply be identified with Johannine theology. It means that Thomas Saying 1 can be investigated within the larger early-Christian question of **Jesus' words and eternal life**.

20. “Taste Death” and Resurrection

There is an important theological difficulty.

Jesus Himself physically died.

Therefore, “not taste death” cannot simply mean:

“The believer will never physically die.”

Christian theology instead understands physical death in relation to resurrection.

Jesus says:

“Though he die, yet shall he live.”

Therefore, “not taste death” may be interpreted in an ultimate sense:

Death will not have the final authority.

This interpretation is more compatible with the resurrection-centered Christian proclamation.

21. The Great Linguistic Movement

We can now construct the complete linguistic progression:

Greek

εὐρίσκω

Find

↓

ἐρμηνεία

Interpretation

↓

λόγοι

Sayings

↓

γεύομαι

Taste/experience

↓

θάνατος

Death

Coptic

finding

↓

ἑρμηνεία

interpretation

↓

ⲱⲗⲟⲩ

sayings/words

↓

ⲭⲓ ⲧⲓⲣⲉ

taste

↓

ܡܕܝܬܐ

death

Aramaic/Syriac comparative framework

find/discover

↓

interpret/explain

↓

miltha — word/saying

↓

taste/experience

↓

death

This is the foundation for a serious comparative study.

22. The Central Discovery

The most important linguistic discovery is not an alleged secret Aramaic word.

It is the relationship between **interpretation and death**.

Thomas Saying 1 does not merely say:

“Jesus' sayings are important.”

It says:

Finding their interpretation has consequences for death.

That is extraordinary.

The reader is invited into a process:

Seek.

Find.

Interpret.

Discover.

Live.

23. Final Theological Interpretation

From the standpoint of Christian theology, this linguistic study can lead toward a profound conclusion.

The sayings cannot ultimately be isolated from the One who speaks them.

The Living Jesus speaks.

His sayings reveal.

The interpretation reveals the mystery.

The mystery points toward life.

And the Christian Gospel identifies Christ as:

the Word

the Life

the Resurrection

the Door

the Way

Thus the saying can be contemplated through this theological progression:

Find the meaning of the sayings.

Discover what the Living Jesus reveals.

Encounter the reality to which His words point.

Receive life.

Do not allow death to have the final word.

24. Conclusion

Gospel of Thomas Saying 1 is a small sentence with an enormous theological horizon.

Its Greek and Coptic witnesses establish a remarkably stable central idea:

The one who finds the interpretation of these sayings will not taste death.

The Coptic text is especially significant because it preserves *θερηνησία*, a Greek loanword corresponding to *ἐρμηνεία*, confirming that “interpretation” is central to the sentence.

The Greek evidence gives us the earlier textual witness.

The Coptic evidence preserves the complete saying.

The Aramaic evidence provides a **comparative Semitic framework**, but not a surviving original manuscript.

Therefore, the responsible scholarly conclusion is:

We can establish the Greek and Coptic wording. We can investigate its Aramaic conceptual environment. But an Aramaic original must remain a reconstruction rather than a proven historical text.

The deeper theological question remains extraordinarily powerful:

What is the interpretation that leads beyond death?

For Christian theology, the answer ultimately leads beyond the written saying to the Living One who spoke it.

“I am the resurrection and the life.”

And:

“The words that I have spoken to you are spirit and life.”

Thus:

The Living Jesus speaks living words.
The living words reveal life.
Life conquers death.
And the Living Word is Jesus Christ.

A Coptic Word Study of Gospel of Thomas Saying 1

Lexical, Morphological, Semantic, and Theological Analysis

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Abstract

The first saying of the *Gospel of Thomas* is one of the most concentrated statements in early Christian sayings literature:

“Whoever finds the interpretation of these sayings will not taste death.”

The complete surviving *Gospel of Thomas* is preserved in Coptic in Nag Hammadi Codex II, while an earlier Greek witness, P.Oxy. 654, preserves the prologue and the opening sayings. This paper focuses exclusively on the **Coptic vocabulary and sentence structure of Saying 1**.

Particular attention is given to the Coptic expressions for **whoever/the one who**, **find**, **interpretation**, **these**, **sayings/words**, **taste**, and **death**. Special consideration is given to the Coptic word ⲉⲣⲏⲏⲏⲉⲓⲁ, a Greek loanword corresponding to Greek ἑρμηνεία, “interpretation.” The study demonstrates that the Coptic sentence is constructed around an important semantic progression: **finding** → **interpretation** → **sayings** → **tasting** → **death**.

The study concludes that the vocabulary of Saying 1 places the act of understanding Jesus' sayings at the center of the statement. A later theological interpretation may connect this concept with the Christian understanding of Jesus as the Living Word and the source of eternal

life, but that theological conclusion must be distinguished from what the Coptic vocabulary itself establishes.

1. Introduction

The *Gospel of Thomas* contains 114 sayings attributed to Jesus.

Its opening saying is unusually important because it tells the reader how the sayings should be approached.

The reader is told that the person who discovers their interpretation will not taste death.

Thus the first saying functions almost like an introduction to the entire collection.

It establishes four major concepts:

1. **the seeker;**
2. **the sayings;**
3. **their interpretation;**
4. **death.**

The central question is:

What does the Coptic vocabulary actually say?

This paper therefore avoids beginning with theology and instead begins with the language.

2. The Coptic Manuscript

The complete surviving Coptic *Gospel of Thomas* is preserved in **Nag Hammadi Codex II**.

The text belongs to the Sahidic Coptic tradition.

The Coptic manuscript provides the primary textual basis for this word study.

The text has also been compared with Greek fragments from Oxyrhynchus. P.Oxy. 654 preserves the prologue and sayings 1–7, making it especially important for textual comparison.

[Coptic Scriptorium — Gospel of Thomas](#)

The present paper, however, concentrates on the **Coptic text itself**.

3. The Coptic Sentence

The opening of Saying 1 may be represented in transliteration approximately as:

pet-a-he e-thermēneia n-nei-shaje ...

The exact manuscript spelling, morphology, segmentation, and editorial normalization should always be checked against the diplomatic/annotated edition.

A common English translation is:

“Whoever finds the interpretation of these sayings will not taste death.”

The important lexical units are:

ⲡⲉⲧ-

the one who / whoever

ⲁⲗⲉ

finds

ⲑⲉⲣⲙⲏⲛⲉⲓⲁ

interpretation

ⲛⲉⲓ / **related demonstrative construction**

these

ⲱⲗⲁⲗⲉ

sayings / words

ⲁⲓ ⲧⲏⲉ

taste

ⲙⲟⲩ

death

The precise grammatical segmentation is important because Coptic often expresses grammatical relationships differently from Greek.

4. Word One: πЄт- — “The One Who / Whoever”

The construction beginning with:

πЄт-

is extremely important.

It forms a relative/generalizing expression that can be rendered:

“the one who...”

or:

“whoever...”

The saying therefore does not identify a particular disciple.

It presents a general principle.

Anyone who performs the action described in the sentence falls under its promise.

The structure can therefore be represented:

πЄт- + **VERB**

the one who + does something

This makes the saying universal in scope.

5. Word Two: ⲁⲩⲉ — “Find”

The next important concept is **finding**.

The Coptic verb is conventionally represented in the text as a form related to the semantic field:

find / discover.

The significance of this word is greater than a simple physical discovery.

The object being found is not an ordinary object.

It is:

the interpretation.

Thus the sentence describes an intellectual/spiritual discovery.

The person must discover something hidden within the sayings.

This creates:

search → discovery → understanding.

6. Word Three: ΘΕΡΜΗΝΕΙΑ — “Interpretation”

This is arguably the most important Coptic word in Saying 1.

Coptic

ΘΕΡΜΗΝΕΙΑ

Greek equivalent

ἐρμηνεία

English

interpretation

The Coptic word is a Greek loanword.

This is linguistically significant.

Rather than replacing the Greek technical term with an entirely native Coptic expression, the translator retains the Greek-derived vocabulary.

Therefore the concept of **interpretation** is explicitly preserved.

7. Semantic Range of ΘΕΡΜΗΝΕΙΑ

The semantic field of Greek ἐρμηνεία includes ideas such as:

- interpretation;
- explanation;
- exposition;
- rendering;
- making meaning understandable.

Consequently, “meaning” can sometimes be an understandable English translation.

But **interpretation** is more precise for the linguistic study.

The saying therefore does not merely say:

“Whoever finds these sayings...”

It says:

“**Whoever finds the interpretation of these sayings...**”

This distinction is fundamental.

8. Word Four: ΝΕΕΙ — “These”

The demonstrative element points specifically to the sayings being presented.

The reader is not being instructed to interpret all religious wisdom in general.

The immediate object is:

these sayings.

The expression creates a direct connection between the introductory statement and the sayings that follow.

9. Word Five: ⲙⲁⲭⲉ — “Sayings / Words”

The Coptic noun:

ⲙⲁⲭⲉ

belongs to the semantic field of:

word / speech / saying.

This is extremely important.

Thomas is a collection of spoken sayings attributed to Jesus.

Therefore the expression refers naturally to the statements of Jesus.

The reader must discover their interpretation.

10. “Sayings” Rather Than “Book”

Notice the literary significance.

The sentence does not say:

“Whoever finds the interpretation of this book...”

It refers to:

these sayings.

The unit of revelation is therefore the **saying**.

This fits the entire literary form of Thomas.

The Gospel is constructed as a collection of individual sayings.

11. Word Six: ⲭⲓ — “Take / Receive”

The Coptic expression concerning tasting includes:

ⲭⲓ

with the basic semantic idea of:

take / receive.

Within the idiomatic expression, it participates in the meaning:

taste.

This illustrates an important characteristic of Coptic translation.

A Coptic expression cannot always be translated by assigning one English word to each Coptic word.

Idiomatic combinations must be interpreted as combinations.

12. Word Seven: ⲧⲡⲉ — “Taste”

The expression:

ⲁⲓ ⲧⲡⲉ

is translated:

“taste.”

The metaphor is significant.

Death is presented as something that can be tasted.

This creates an experiential image.

The statement is therefore stronger than merely saying:

“will not think about death.”

It describes freedom from experiencing death.

13. Word Eight: ⲙⲟⲩ — “Death”

The final key noun is:

ⲙⲟⲩ

meaning:

death.

The sentence ends with death.

This is rhetorically powerful.

The entire statement begins with the seeker:

whoever...

and ends with:

death.

Between these two points is:

the interpretation of the sayings.

Thus the entire sentence can be understood as a movement from:

seeker

to

interpretation

to

sayings

to

life beyond death.

14. Coptic Lexical Table

Coptic	Transliteration	Basic sense	Function in Saying 1
ⲡⲉⲧ-	pet-	the one who	introduces the seeker

ⲁⲗⲉ	ahe	find	describes discovery
ⲑⲉⲣⲙⲏⲛⲉⲓⲁ	hermēneia	interpretation	object of discovery
ⲛⲉⲉⲓ	nee-i	these	identifies the sayings
ⲱⲁⲭⲉ	shaje	word/saying	object of interpretation
ⲭⲓ	ji	take/receive	part of idiom
ⲧⲏⲉ	tipe	taste	experiential action
ⲙⲟⲩ	mou	death	ultimate object

This table provides the lexical skeleton of the saying.

15. The Coptic Semantic Structure

The vocabulary can be arranged into five stages:

1. Person

ⲡⲉⲧ-

The one who...

2. Discovery

ⲁⲗⲉ

finds...

3. Interpretation

ἑρμηνεία

the interpretation...

4. Revelation

ⲱⲗⲁⲗⲉ

of the sayings...

5. Death

ⲛⲟⲩ

will not taste death.

The conceptual movement is therefore:

Person → Discovery → Interpretation → Sayings → Death

16. Why the Coptic Loanword Matters

The presence of ἑρμηνεία is especially important because it preserves the Greek conceptual terminology.

This gives us a linguistic bridge:

Coptic ἑρμηνεία ← **Greek** ἑρμηνεία

Therefore, the Coptic translator's wording confirms that the idea of **interpretation** belongs centrally to the textual tradition.

The saying is fundamentally about **discovering interpretation**.

17. Coptic and the Concept of Hidden Meaning

The saying appears in the opening of a collection introduced as sayings of the living Jesus.

The reader is told that their interpretation must be found.

This creates the idea of **hidden meaning**.

The words are visible.

Their deeper significance is not necessarily immediately visible.

Thus:

The saying is spoken openly, but its meaning may remain hidden.

This distinction is important for understanding the literary character of Thomas.

18. Theological Interpretation

Once the Coptic lexical study is complete, theology can ask what the saying means.

The vocabulary itself establishes:

finding the interpretation of Jesus' sayings is connected with not tasting death.

The text itself does not explicitly explain the mechanism.

Therefore theological interpretations must be identified as interpretations.

One possible Christian reading connects this with canonical sayings such as:

“The words that I have spoken to you are spirit and life.”

— John 6:63

and:

“If anyone keeps my word, he will never see death.”

— John 8:51

These texts create a striking theological parallel.

19. Jesus as the Living Word

The Christian theological tradition can take the investigation further.

John declares:

“In the beginning was the Word.”

And:

“The Word became flesh.”

Therefore, according to Johannine Christianity, Jesus Christ is not merely a person who speaks God's words.

He is the **Word made flesh**.

This creates a profound theological relationship:

The Living Word speaks living words.

But this must be clearly identified as **Christian theological synthesis**, rather than claiming that every element of Johannine theology is explicitly contained in Thomas Saying 1.

20. Saying 1 and Eternal Life

The Coptic vocabulary creates an extraordinary conceptual movement:

Interpretation → sayings → not tasting death.

The saying therefore places understanding at the threshold of death.

The seeker discovers something in the sayings that changes his or her relationship to death.

The precise nature of that transformation is left unexplained.

That ambiguity is part of the mystery of the saying.

21. The “Meaning” Is Not Merely Information

The word ἑρμηνεία should not be reduced to dictionary knowledge.

To “find the interpretation” may imply discovering what the sayings actually signify.

The difference is:

Knowing the words

versus

understanding the reality to which the words point.

This distinction is central to the theological significance of the saying.

22. The Coptic Word Study and Christology

A strictly linguistic study cannot prove that Thomas Saying 1 teaches:

“Jesus is the eternal Logos.”

That doctrine belongs explicitly to the Johannine prologue.

However, a theological comparison can ask:

If Jesus is the Living Word, what does it mean to discover the meaning of His words?

The answer within Christian theology is profound:

His words reveal Him.

And He reveals the Father.

23. The Mystery of Death

The final word of the sentence is:

ⲙⲟⲩ — **death.**

This gives the entire saying an eschatological dimension.

The reader begins by seeking meaning.

The sentence ends by confronting death.

This may be summarized:

Understanding the sayings is presented as having consequences beyond ordinary earthly existence.

That is why Saying 1 has attracted such theological attention.

24. Conclusion

The Coptic vocabulary of Gospel of Thomas Saying 1 reveals a remarkably concentrated sentence.

Its major lexical elements create the following movement:

ⲡⲉⲧ- — **the one who**

finds

ⲉⲣⲡⲏⲛⲉⲓⲁ — **interpretation**

of the sayings

will not taste

ⲙⲟⲩ — **death.**

The most significant lexical feature is ⲉⲣⲡⲏⲛⲉⲓⲁ, the Greek-derived Coptic term for interpretation. Its presence demonstrates that the concept of **interpretation** is not incidental to the sentence.

The saying therefore establishes a relationship between:

finding

and

understanding

and

life beyond death.

The Coptic vocabulary itself does not settle exactly what “not tasting death” means. That requires theological and comparative interpretation.

Nevertheless, the sentence's central challenge is unmistakable:

Do not merely hear the sayings. Find their interpretation.

And the promise attached to that discovery is extraordinary:

“You will not taste death.”

For Christian theology, the question then moves beyond vocabulary:

What do the sayings reveal about the One who spoke them?

That question leads naturally to the Johannine proclamation:

“The Word became flesh.”

The linguistic study therefore provides the foundation; Christological interpretation comes afterward.

Research Principle

A rigorous study of Thomas Saying 1 should maintain three distinct levels:

COPTIC TEXT

What does the surviving manuscript actually say?

↓

LINGUISTICS

What do its words and grammatical constructions mean?

↓

THEOLOGY

What does the saying mean when read within early Christian understandings of Jesus, life, and death?

Keeping these three levels separate allows the research to be both **linguistically responsible** and **theologically profound**.

Coptic Language Note

Gospel of Thomas — Saying 1

Coptic Text

ⲡⲉⲧⲁⲕⲉ ⲉⲑⲉⲣⲙⲏⲛⲉⲓⲁ ⲛⲏⲉⲉⲓ ⲥⲁⲛⲁ ⲛⲓ ⲧⲓⲡⲉ ⲁⲛ ⲙⲓⲧⲙⲟⲩ

Transliteration

pet-a-he e-thermēneia n-neeī-shaje
f-na ji tipe an m-p-mou

Word-by-Word

Coptic	Transliteration	Meaning
ⲡⲉⲧ-	pet-	the one who / whoever
ⲁⲕⲉ	ahe	finds
ⲉ-	e-	to / into / infinitival-construction marker
ⲉⲣⲙⲏⲛⲉⲓⲁ	thermēneia	interpretation
ⲛⲏⲉⲉⲓ	n-neeī	of these

ⲩⲁⲭⲉ	shaje	sayings / words
ϥ-	f-	he
ⲛⲁ-	na-	future marker
ⲭⲓ	ji	take
ⲧⲡⲉ	tipe	taste
ⲁⲛ	an	not
ⲙ-	m-	of / object-linking element
ⲡⲓⲙⲟⲩ	p-mou	the death

Literal Sense

“The one who finds the interpretation of these sayings, he will not taste the death.”

Natural English

“Whoever finds the interpretation of these sayings will not taste death.”

Important Coptic Word: ⲑⲉⲣⲙⲏⲛⲉⲓⲁ

ⲑⲉⲣⲙⲏⲛⲉⲓⲁ

This is a Coptic form borrowed from Greek:

ἐρμηνεία — hermēneia

Meaning:

interpretation, explanation, rendering, explanation of meaning.

This is the key word in Saying 1.

The sentence does not merely say:

“Whoever finds these sayings...”

It says:

“Whoever finds the interpretation of these sayings...”

Therefore, the Coptic text places **interpretation/understanding** at the center of the saying.

ΠΗΗΝΕΙΑ and Interpretation

The Coptic form preserves the Greek-derived concept rather than replacing it with a completely different native expression.

This gives us:

Greek: ἐρμηνεία

Coptic: ΠΗΗΗΝΕΙΑ

English: interpretation

The word therefore provides a direct linguistic bridge between the Greek and Coptic witnesses.

ⲱⲗⲭⲉ — Saying / Word

ⲱⲗⲭⲉ

has the semantic field of:

word

speech

saying

utterance

In Saying 1, it refers to the sayings attributed to Jesus.

The phrase therefore has the conceptual structure:

interpretation of the sayings

rather than simply:

the sayings themselves.

MOY — Death

MOY

means:

death

The sentence ends with this word.

The movement of the sentence is consequently:

Whoever → finds → interpretation → sayings → will not taste → death.

The entire statement moves from **discovery** toward **death**.

ⲭⲓ ⲧⲡⲉ — “Taste”

The expression translated “taste” contains:

ⲭⲓ — take/receive

and

ⲧⲡⲉ — taste

Together they produce the idiomatic idea:

to taste / experience.

Thus “taste death” is an experiential expression.

It can be understood as:

experience death.

Coptic Sentence Structure

The sentence can be visually arranged:

ⲡⲉⲧ-

the one who

↓

ⲁⲗⲉ

finds

↓

ⲉⲉⲣⲙⲏⲛⲉⲓⲁ

interpretation

↓

ⲱⲗⲁⲗⲉ

sayings

↓

ⲉⲛⲁⲗⲁ...

he will...

↓

ⲁⲓ ⲛⲉ

taste

↓

ⲙⲟⲩ

death

Central Coptic Concept

ⲑⲉⲣⲙⲏⲉⲓⲁ — **interpretation**

The sentence places this concept between **finding** and **death**.

Coptic Theological Observation

The Coptic text itself should first be treated linguistically.

It tells us:

Find the interpretation of these sayings → do not taste death.

A theological interpretation can then ask what this means.

The Gospel of John provides a striking comparison:

“The words that I have spoken to you are spirit and life.”

— John 6:63

And:

“If anyone keeps my word, he will never see death.”

— John 8:51

And:

“I am the resurrection and the life.”

— John 11:25

Therefore, within Christian theology, the Coptic Saying 1 can be contemplated in relation to the broader mystery of **Christ's words, life, and victory over death**.

But the linguistic observation must remain distinct from the theological interpretation.

Final Coptic Formula

ⲡⲉⲧⲁⲉ

The one who finds

ΘΕΡΜΗΝΕΙΑ

the interpretation

ΝΗΕΕΙ ΥΔΧΕ

of these sayings

ϢΝΔ ΧΙ †ΠΕ ΔΝ

he will not taste

ΜΠΜΟΥ

death

The central message:

“Whoever finds the interpretation of these sayings will not taste death.”

The Coptic language therefore preserves a powerful sequence:

ΔΖΕ — **FIND**

→

ΘΕΡΜΗΝΕΙΑ — **INTERPRET**

→

ΥΔΧΕ — **SAYINGS**

→

ΧΙ †ΠΕ — **TASTE**

→

ΜΟΥ — **DEATH**

The seeker finds.

The seeker understands.

The sayings are interpreted.

Death is no longer the final reality.

